



Visa bureaucracy causing GPs to leave the UK

The UK is desperate for General Practitioners but administrative burden is forcing some overseas trainees to consider changing career, move house, or leave the country. Jacqui Thornton reports.

For the Health Foundation's report on GP shortages see <https://www.health.org.uk/news-and-comment/news-more-than-a-quarter-of-gp-and-general-practice-nursing-posts-could-be-vacant-in-10-years>

Hundreds of trainee GPs in the UK are preparing to complete their training in August to allow them to start independent practice as GPs. But for doctors who gained their medical degree abroad before coming to the UK to specialise in primary care, their joy is muted by the stress of trying to find an employer who will sponsor them to legally remain in the country.

For many there is a growing fear that they might be forced to take a job outside general practice to comply with complex visa rules. Some feel their only option is to uproot themselves and their families from their homes to find a GP employer who will sponsor them with a skilled worker visa, work in a hospital where the process is easier, or even return to their home country. In extreme cases, these doctors, known as international medical graduates, could be removed from the country by the UK Home Office, the government department that oversees visas.

In June, 2022, The Royal College of General Practitioners' (RCGP) Vice Chair of Professional Development, Margaret Ikpoh, told the House of Commons Health and Social Care Committee that she is regularly contacted by GPs who, once qualified, have received letters threatening "deportation". Indefinite leave to remain in the UK is given after living 5 years in the country. This requirement is not a problem for trainees in most specialties, where training takes more than 5 years; but because GP training usually takes only 3 years, GPs need visa sponsorship from an employer for the final 2 years before they are eligible for indefinite leave to remain status. Setting up as a sponsor is seen as bureaucratic by practices, so there is limited supply and a lot of demand, particularly in rural areas with fewer employers and reduced administrative capacity.

On June 28, the British Medical Association (BMA), which represents doctors, held a debate on the issue at its Annual Representative Meeting. The members voted to make it BMA policy to call for the mandating of a 5-year minimum visa award to doctors entering UK GP training programmes. One speaker told of a colleague from Nigeria who had been on the brink of deportation because he had not met the requisite rules.

In England, 47% of new GP trainees in 2021–22 were international medical graduates, and there are estimated to be 1000 trainees on visas that will expire by the end of March, 2023, according to Health Education England, the body which coordinates training. This is problematic given the shortage of GPs in the UK. On June 30, the think-tank the Health Foundation published a study which found that the current 4200 shortfall of GPs in England could rise to more than 10 000 by 2030–31, with one in four posts vacant. Although the numbers entering the profession are on the rise, they will be offset by GPs retiring or choosing part-time working.

Andrew Wilson, who proposed the BMA motion to give overseas GPs a minimum 5-year visa, said the current system was bad for the trainee, bad for general practice, and bad for the taxpayer and the wider NHS. He said, "One cannot fathom that in this time of extreme GP, nay doctor shortage, why the government insist on making these GP trainees jump through these hoops causing some to leave the UK".

GP Registrar Aishwarya Kasha was one of the first to speak up about the trainees' concern at a Local Medical Committee conference in March, 2022, in Wales. At the time Kasha and her partner, also a GP trainee and who both gained their MBBS in India, could not find a practice to sponsor them

where they were training in Swansea, south Wales, and considered moving to England, Scotland, or Northern Ireland to get a sponsored job. She came across a Facebook page for GPs in training that suggested using an agency, which helped find them jobs in Gwent an hour away. "We kept looking for jobs, we kept all our options open, and thankfully it worked out for us", she said. Since then, several practices in Swansea have agreed to become sponsors.

One trainee GP in England who spoke to *The Lancet* anonymously said she is concerned about the situation, particularly as she comes from a country where the GP specialty does not exist. "My options are getting pregnant and going on maternity leave to push my training, or I could go back to working in a hospital as a junior doctor because hospitals can provide visas."

The Doctors' Association UK advocacy group, which described the problem as "foolish bureaucratic madness", is setting up a resource to link international medical graduate trainees with GP practices looking to recruit, to help people in similar situations. The Home Office has accused the RCGP of "needless scaremongering" and said it has no plans to reduce the 5-year qualifying period for settlement, adding that "there is no evidence whatsoever to support claims we are removing GPs from the UK".

Kasha is grateful for the RCGP's lobbying on this. She says, "The training is pressured and stressful enough and this is an added pressure, so we need a long-term solution. It is not ideal... Just because our issue has been sorted out, I will never stop speaking on it. There are good hardworking doctors everywhere who are being affected by this."

Jacqui Thornton